

KILL GATE ZERO — operational reality audit of G, H and I

Date: 2026-08-24 · **Gate authority:** [SAS/prompt-kit-ep1-challengers-v2.0.pdf](#), Kill Gate Zero · **Subjects:** the three incumbent premises, which predate the gate and have never been through it.

Scope and honesty statement

This audit was run **without external research**. That is a real limitation and it bounds what the results mean.

It does not bound them as much as it might, because of where the three premises actually fail. Only one of the findings below turns on a process fact that would need a primary source (Pitch G's death-certification and referral chain). Every other finding turns on the **antagonist least-cost test** and the **commonsense challenge**, which are logic, not lookup: why does the criminal do the elaborate thing when a simpler and safer thing achieves the same end.

Where a real-world baseline is asserted, it is marked **BASELINE** and describes the broadly shared common-law position, which is what the gate instructs when the jurisdiction is not canonical. Havenbay's jurisdiction is not canonical. Anything marked **NEEDS SOURCE** must be verified against a primary source before it reaches script, not before it reaches a ruling.

The finding that applies to all three, stated first

The three premises fail or wobble on one axis, and **it is not the axis the previous audits were looking at**.

Yesterday's deficit blocks were about story completeness: no named beneficiary, no wrong hypothesis, Havenbay-decorative rather than Havenbay-dependent. Those are real and they remain. Kill Gate Zero fails these premises somewhere else entirely: **the antagonist behaves the way the player's puzzle needs, rather than the way a person protecting themselves would behave**.

That is worth stating plainly because of where the premises came from. They were generated in-house, optimising for hook and structure, by the same process that then audited them. The v2.0 prompt's diagnosis of why the external attempt produced unbelievable premises applies without modification to this work: a compelling hook was allowed to buy permission for behaviour nobody would actually choose.

PITCH G — "The Confession"

First five causal events

#	Event	Actor	Authority	Custody	Normal response	Safeguard	Bypass	Trace
1	Doyle confesses a 1989 killing to Gerald in a bar booth	Doyle	None needed. A conversation.	Doyle owns his own words	A retired detective writes it down and takes it seriously	None applies	None needed	Gerald's notebook, Mo as a witness to the meeting
2	Gerald records the conversation	Gerald	NEEDS RULING. One-party versus two-party consent recording	Gerald holds the recording	Retired police instinct: preserve it	Two-party-consent rules would make a covert recording unlawful and possibly inadmissible	If Havenbay is one-party, no bypass needed	The recording itself
3	Doyle dies within hours	Killer	None. Homicide.	Killer controls the scene briefly, then the body is found	A dying eighty-one-year-old found dead is a certifiable death	This is the real safeguard, and it does not obstruct the killer, it helps him	No bypass needed. The victim's terminal illness is the disguise	Injection site, toxicology if anyone looks
4	The death is treated as suspicious	Gerald, then Del	Gerald reports; Del escalates	Coroner or medical examiner takes custody once referred	BASELINE: a death is referred to the coroner when sudden, unexpected, unnatural or unattended. A terminal patient seen recently by a doctor can be certified	The referral is what the killer needed to avoid, and Gerald defeats it	Killer cannot bypass a credible witness reporting a confession hours before death	The referral record itself

#	Event	Actor	Authority	Custody	Normal response	Safeguard	Bypass	Trace
					without referral			
5	Cortez finds the injection site and orders toxicology	Cortez	Coronial post-mortem authority	Coroner	Full external examination, then targeted toxicology	Toxicology is ordered only when something prompts it	Nothing to bypass; the killer already lost at event 4	Findings become the case

The commonsense challenge

Why do the police not prevent this? They are not present. Nothing here requires police failure, which is the healthiest sign in the audit.

Why does the coroner permit it? They do not, and that is the point. The story's own engine defeats the concealment. **But the pitch currently skips events 4 and 5 entirely** and states that "Dr. Cortez finds the injection site behind the knee" as though Ally has walked into a morgue. She has not and cannot. The chain must run Gerald reports, Del escalates, the coroner refers, the post-mortem happens, and Del tells Ally what she is not supposed to.

Why is Ally present and allowed? Legitimately, in most of the episode. June's biscuit tin is June's property. The 1989 inquest is **BASELINE** a public proceeding with a public record. The Rusty Anchor is Mo's and Mo invites her. The one thing she cannot have is post-mortem findings, and Del's canon function is precisely the deniable route for that. This is the cleanest access profile of the three premises.

Why does the victim not take the obvious protective action? Doyle is eighty-one, terminal, and has decided to spend the last thing he owns. He is not trying to survive. Coherent.

What would an informed viewer object to in the first beat? "Why did an old man confess to a stranger in a bar?" The answer is available and the pitch does not use it: **he did not confess to a stranger**. He chose a retired detective, deliberately, because he wanted it written down by someone who would know what to do with it. Making that explicit converts the weakest question in the cold open into the strongest.

Antagonist least-cost test

This is where G nearly dies, and where the fix makes it better.

Why murder? The pitch has no answer, and the obvious objection is fatal as written: **Doyle is terminally ill and dying within months**. Killing a man who is about to die anyway takes an enormous risk for a few weeks of silence. A rational antagonist waits.

Worse: Doyle **had already talked**. The confession is out. Killing him does not recall it.

The repair, and it is a strengthening rather than a patch. Killing Doyle does not erase the confession. It changes what the confession legally **is**.

BASELINE: a statement by a person who is now dead, repeated by a listener, is hearsay, and is generally inadmissible to prove the truth of what it asserts, subject to exceptions that vary by jurisdiction. A living Doyle

giving a formal statement to police is evidence. A dead Doyle is Gerald's word about what a dead man said in a bar.

So the antagonist is not silencing a man. **He is converting hard evidence into hearsay, inside the window before Doyle can repeat it on the record.** That is rational, specific, time-pressured, and it explains the speed. It also explains why Gerald is next: he is the only surviving conduit, and his notebook is the only contemporaneous record.

Why this method? Covert injection staged as a heart attack in a terminal patient is the method with the highest chance of no post-mortem at all. Correct choice for this antagonist.

Why not something easier? Intimidating a dying man is useless. Buying him is useless. He has already decided. Murder is genuinely the cheapest remaining option once he has talked, which is what the test is asking for.

Verdict

CONDITIONAL PASS. Two mandatory repairs, both of which improve the story:

1. **Show the custody chain.** Gerald reports, Del escalates, the coroner refers, the post-mortem happens, Del leaks. Ally never touches a body or a report. Roughly one lead of structure and it makes Del and Gerald more competent, not less.
2. **Make the motive the hearsay conversion.** The killer is racing a formal statement, not a confession. This must be said out loud in the episode, ideally by Del, because it is the sentence that makes the murder rational.

One item to rule: **NEEDS RULING — recording consent.** Gerald's recording of the confession is load-bearing for the whole third phase. If Havenbay follows a two-party-consent rule, that recording is unlawfully obtained and probably unusable, and the branch built on airing it is built on sand. One-party consent is the more common baseline, and this is a Havenbay canon ruling rather than a research question. It cannot be assumed silently.

Nothing in G requires an institution to lack a power it has, or a professional to be absent, slow or incurious. That is the test it passes and the other two do not.

PITCH H — "The Overnight Girl"

Stephen's read on 2026-08-24, before this audit: *"The premise is weak. One ring, two rings, she made me learn this number in case it ever rang once, she said ask for Ally, say the diner, say the ice store, say run. Weak sauce indeed, very tenuous and barely believable."*

The gate agrees, and finds two failures more serious than the code.

First five causal events

#	Event	Actor	Authority	Custody	Normal response	Safeguard	Bypass	Trace
1	A customs clerk photographs his manifests	The clerk	None. Probably a breach of his employment terms	He holds the images	Employer audits access logs; a regulator receives a disclosure	Whistleblower channels exist and he does not use them	UNEXPLAINED	Camera, access logs, his own copies
2	Two men kill him and move the body	The killers	None. Homicide	They control the body for the transit	Nothing yet, he is not missed	None operating at night	None needed	Vehicle, route, timing
3	They store the body in a commercial fish-market ice store	The killers	NONE. This is the first hard failure.	A commercial premises with staff, deliveries, temperature logs and inspections	Staff open it in the morning	Every safeguard a working premises has	NO CREDIBLE BYPASS IS OFFERED	Discovery, guaranteed, within hours
4	Nina sees it through a window and runs	Nina	Hers	She controls only herself	BASELINE: a witness to a body disposal calls emergency services	Emergency response is the safeguard, and she declines it	Explained by witness-protection fallout distrust	Her absence
5	A professional searches for her by visiting her trust network	The hunter	None	He controls nothing	Each person visited can describe him afterwards	Every visit is a witness. This is the highest-exposure search method available	NO BYPASS. He is choosing the most traceable option	A line of witnesses pointing at him

The three failures, in order of severity

1. The antagonist's search method is the worst available and he has a better one sitting in front of him

This is the automatic fail.

The hunter is described as patient, professional, and methodical, and he searches by **visiting everyone Nina ever trusted, one polite conversation at a time**. Every one of those conversations creates a witness who can describe his face, his voice, his manner and his exact change. He is manufacturing the case against himself, door by door, in exchange for information any of those people may not even have.

Meanwhile, there is a twelve-year-old boy who is the one person on earth Nina is guaranteed to contact.

A professional watches the brother and waits. That is cheaper, safer, faster and generates no witnesses. The gate's wording is exact: *if the antagonist is performing an elaborate thriller mechanism only because the player needs a puzzle, fail the seed*. The trust-network tour exists so that the player has three doors to choose between. It has no other reason to exist.

There is a version of this that works, and it is a different story: **the hunter sits on the boy, which means the hunter is already standing where Ally is standing**. That is tighter, cheaper and considerably more frightening. It also destroys the triage mechanic, which was H's best feature.

2. Why murder the clerk at all

The least-cost test is not answered anywhere. A customs clerk copying manifests can be transferred, discredited, suspended pending an audit, quietly bought, or made redundant. Any of those ends the problem without bringing a homicide investigation onto the smuggling route, which is the single outcome an ongoing criminal operation least wants.

Killing him is the most expensive option on the menu and the pitch does not say why it was chosen. A workable answer exists (he had already sent the photographs somewhere and the killing was about recovering them, or he was not meant to die), but the premise does not currently have one, and **UNKNOWN on the foundation is FAIL**.

3. The ice store

A body is put in a working commercial cold store with staff, deliveries, temperature logs and health inspections. It will be found the next morning, which the story requires, but the killers cannot want that.

The harbour is right there. It is the setting. Weighting a body and putting it in deep water at night is the cheapest, oldest and most available disposal in this city, and 1989's Wren Kellaway is proof that the story world already knows it works.

The ice store exists because the audience needs the body found. That is a choice made for the reader, not by the characters, and the gate exists to catch exactly that.

Making it deliberate would repair it: the body is meant to be found, because finding it is a message to someone. But that is a different criminal intent and it changes the episode.

The code, which is what Stephen objected to

He is right that it is tenuous, and it is worth separating why, because the weakness is not where it first appears.

Two rings meaning safe is fine. Families invent rituals. The problems are the load-bearing parts around it:

- **A twelve-year-old maintains a nightly vigil for years**. Every night, at ten past three, awake and monitoring. That is not a ritual, it is a job, and children do not sustain it.

- **The fallback routes to a podcaster rather than to emergency services.** The pitch explains this as distrust of police from witness-protection fallout. That explains not calling the police. It does not explain choosing a woman with a microphone who has no power to protect anybody. A person with that history calls a lawyer, a journalist at a masthead, or an agency outside the local force, or tells no one and runs.
- **The boy's line does the plan's work out loud.** "She said ask for Ally, she said say the diner, say the ice store, say run" is four instructions in one breath. It reads as a plot delivery rather than a frightened child, which is the thing that made it land as weak sauce on a first read.

None of these three is individually fatal. Together they are the sound of a premise being held up rather than standing.

Verdict

FAIL.

Not "needs work". The no-quota rule is explicit that a failure is not softened to keep a candidate alive. H fails on antagonist rationality twice, on an unexplained choice of murder, and on a disposal site chosen for the audience.

What is worth keeping. Nina's competence is genuinely good and rare: a victim who is the most capable person in the episode and who is not waiting to be rescued. The accumulating ending, where the player earns which version of the boathouse they get, is still the best agency design anyone has produced for this project.

Both survive a rebuild. Neither survives inside this premise, because the triage mechanic is the direct product of the search method that fails the gate.

PITCH I — "The Last Caller"

Stephen's read: *"Very very contrived. Old man making a death bed confession is presumably assaulted at the precise second that he is about to say the name of a nine year old girl/stranger. Much too contrived and unbelievable."*

Correct, and the gate lets us be precise about which part is contrived, because it is not the timing.

The interruption is not a coincidence problem. It is an antagonist-rationality problem.

The instinct on a first read is that the timing is impossibly lucky. It is not, and the pitch is careful about this: the interrupter is **in the room**. They are listening to the whole call. Reacting at the name requires no luck at all.

Which is precisely the failure.

Somebody who can put a hand over the receiver at second eighty-eight could have done it at second one. They chose not to. So a rational actor listened to a man:

- state that a 1989 death was a murder,

- state that it was staged as an accident,
- state that he was paid to lie about it,
- state that the payer's voice is known to him,
- state that a witness exists,

and only intervened at her name.

Every one of those disclosures is catastrophic on its own. The confession alone reopens a closed homicide, establishes a paid cover-up and proves a witness exists. Letting nine tenths of it out to keep one tenth in is strictly worse for the interrupter than stopping the call at the first sentence. There is no version of self-interest that produces this behaviour.

This is a clean automatic fail on the least-cost test. The interrupter behaves as they do because the episode needs a specific piece of missing information, which is the definition of a mechanism built for the player rather than by the character.

The repairs, and what each costs

Repair one: they arrive mid-call. Removes the contrivance and removes the premise. The chill was entirely in the permitting.

Repair two: a carer who does not understand until the word "witness". Fails. They would have understood at "I was paid to say it was", thirty seconds earlier.

Repair three, and it is the only one that works. The interrupter is **not the killer and not the payer**. They are a third party who wants the 1989 murder exposed and the witness protected, or preserved as leverage. They let the confession run because the confession serves them. They stopped the name because the name is the only part that costs them.

That repair keeps every frame of the cold open, makes the behaviour rational, and turns the episode inside out: the hand over the receiver belongs to someone who is, in a horrible and self-interested way, on the witness's side. It is a better story than the one pitched. It is also a **different** story, and per the gate's revision rule a candidate may be revised once only if the repair preserves the core premise. This one changes who the antagonist is, so it is a new premise requiring its own audit rather than a patch.

Second failure: the evidence proves more than its nature permits

The gate forbids letting a piece of evidence prove more than it really can.

The pitch has Ally **identify the dead caller** from the recording: a foghorn interval, a medication rattle, and room tone.

- A foghorn interval can narrow a location to a district. **BASELINE**, and it is genuinely the best forensic idea in the pack.
- A pill bottle rattle cannot identify a prescription. It is a rattle.
- Room tone can suggest a room's size and hardness, not an address.

Together they narrow to a neighbourhood, not to a man. As written this is magical forensics.

It is also unnecessary, which is the frustrating part. **He is dead by morning and his body is found.** He has a name the moment a police officer looks at him. The recording never needed to identify him. It needs to prove what he said and when, which it does effortlessly.

Third: Ally's access

She has a recording, which is hers. Everything else in the second phase is archive and public record, which is legitimate. Cause of death comes through Del. That profile is fine. **This is not where I fails.**

Verdict

FAIL as pitched. One automatic fail on antagonist rationality, one on evidential over-claim.

The over-claim is a cheap fix. The interruption is not: the only repair that survives scrutiny replaces the antagonist, and that is a new premise.

What is worth keeping, and it is a great deal. The cold open is still the best sixty seconds written for this project. The four seconds of two people breathing is the strongest single image in the pack. A victim who does not know she is a victim is the sharpest jeopardy statement any of the three produced. And "somebody let a dying man have his conscience and stopped him at the only sentence that mattered" survives intact under repair three, and gets better.

Results

	Kill Gate Zero	Decisive reason
G, The Confession	CONDITIONAL PASS	Nothing requires an institution to lack a power or a professional to be incurious. Two repairs required, both strengthening. One canon ruling outstanding.
H, The Overnight Girl	FAIL	The hunter chooses the highest-exposure search method available while ignoring the one person the target must contact. Plus: murder unexplained against cheaper alternatives, and a disposal site chosen for the audience.
I, The Last Caller	FAIL	A rational interrupter in the room stops the call at sentence one. Permitting nine tenths of a confession to prevent one tenth serves the player, not the character. Plus magical forensics on the caller's identity.

What this changes

The slate is one premise, not three. That is an uncomfortable result and it is the correct one under the no-quota rule, which exists precisely so that a gate is not softened to preserve a comfortable number of options.

It also means the table-read cannot proceed as designed. A blind comparative read of three cold opens needs three premises that survive scrutiny, because a tester choosing a cold open is choosing an episode, and two of these episodes cannot be built as described.

Three honest observations

1. The gate failed these on an axis the previous audits never examined. Yesterday's deficit blocks were about story completeness: no named beneficiary, no wrong hypothesis, Havenbay-decorative. All still true and all secondary. Kill Gate Zero failed two premises on **antagonist rationality**, which no earlier pass tested at all, and which Stephen reached unaided on a single read.

2. These premises were written in-house and audited in-house by the same process. The v2.0 prompt was written because an external model produced three unbelievable stories. Applying its gate to our own work finds the same defect class. A hook was allowed to buy permission for behaviour nobody would choose. That is not a comment about a model; it is a comment about what happens when the same process generates and evaluates.

3. The failures cluster on the two premises with the strongest hooks. H has the clearest jeopardy in the pack. I has the best sixty seconds anyone has written for this project. G, the survivor, is the one that was ranked third on cold-open pull. That correlation is worth sitting with, because it suggests the thing that made a premise exciting on the page was, in both failing cases, the thing that required someone to act against their own interest.

What is salvageable, precisely

From H: Nina's competence, a victim who is the most capable person in the episode and is not waiting to be rescued. And the accumulating ending, where the player earns which version of the climax they get, which remains the best agency design produced for this project. Neither survives inside this premise, because the triage mechanic is a direct product of the search method that failed.

From I: the cold open, essentially intact. The interrupted confession, the hand over the receiver, four seconds of two people breathing. And the sharpest jeopardy sentence in the pack: a woman who does not know she is being looked for. Under the third repair, where the interrupter is a self-interested third party who wanted the confession made but not the witness named, all of it survives and improves. That is a new premise and needs its own audit.

Recommended next steps, in order

- 1. Rule the recording-consent question.** Whether Gerald's recording of the confession is lawful in Havenbay is a canon ruling, not a research question, and Pitch G's entire third phase is built on it.

2. **Apply G's two repairs.** The custody chain, roughly one lead of structure, and the hearsay-conversion motive, which is a sentence Del says out loud.
3. **Do not run the table-read on a field of one.** Either rebuild toward a comparison or accept that the read becomes a single-premise validation, which answers a different question: not which of these do you want, but do you want this at all.
4. **Consider the I repair as a fresh candidate.** It keeps the best cold open in the pack and it is the cheapest route back to a comparative read. It must go through Kill Gate Zero from the beginning, not be grandfathered.
5. **Run any new challengers through v2.0,** which is now the controlled process, rather than through the retired v1.

Governance note

Per the change-control discipline in v2.0, this audit is an execution record and not an amendment to any pitch. G, H and I are unchanged in [episode-1-pitches-v3.2](#) and in the story pack. Nothing here has been quietly edited into them. If Stephen accepts these findings, the pitch document gains a results row and the failing premises are marked, in a separate commit, so the audit trail shows what was believed, when, and on what evidence.

Limitation restated: this audit ran without external research. The only finding that turns on a sourced process fact is Pitch G's death-certification and referral chain, marked BASELINE above, and it must be verified before script. Every failure finding is logic, and would not change with a source.